

age of twits

How many followers do you have? Who are you tweeting with? These are the newest markers of status as urban Indians give a thumbs up to life in 140 characters.

By Gunjeet Sra and Natascha Shah

It's the place for a sugar rush from celebrity mush. From Salman Khan's painting of his beloved daschunds Myson and Myjaan which adorns his living room to Shah Rukh Khan's bathroom at 3.30 a.m. when he's looking into his shaving mirror, from Priyanka Chopra's holiday snaps with a friend to Sonam Kapoor's quick review of Alice Sebold's *The Lovely Bones*, it's a first stop for the gossip guzzler. It's an FIR for journalists looking for an inside scoop, from Lalit Modi asking for transparency in Team Kochi to Shashi Tharoor demanding sympathy. And it's certainly an arena for the bold and the delusional like Mallika Sherawat to insist on telling the world what she's doing, or not. All in short-hand English, with exclamation marks.

Welcome to twitterverse, banality's latest address. It's where fellow twits engage in word play and sometimes suffer death by twitter. It's where

reputations are sunk almost as fast as they're made—ask Chetan Bhagat, the great champion of democracy when it came to credit for *3 Idiots*, and a little Hitler when he tried to block an irksome twit. And it's where the non-twitter class can feel like celebrities, travelling with the stars as they take a dip in the Ganga like Preity Zinta and then negate all that goodness by meeting Chandraswami or step into Abhishek Bachchan's shoes as he nods off listening to David Geuttha. Or even keep up with the 78-year-old Shammi Kapoor as he flirts with Bollywood's leading ladies, scolding Zinta for not reacting to his tweets and inviting Deepika Padukone for a cup of coffee at his home.

And hey, it's also the latest status check. How many followers do you have? Who just tweeted you? And even, did your tweet bring down a minister or at least instigate an income tax raid?

Stars of the Twitosphere

They shoot pictures at their own shoots, they clarify their relationship status and they broadcast positive reviews. Celebrities, they are just like us.



Shah Rukh Khan

twitter style

He shares and bares it all. His tweets are as honest as they can get.

top tweets

"Someone asked me how do I make so much money when I keep tweeting all day. Beats me. Must be something to do with acting for the last 20 years."

"One calculation for reaching the semis was so ridiculously absurd that wotever lil maths i knew went flying out of the window. ha ha"

number of followers

2,92,415